

July 26, 2026

Search Committee — Chief Data and Governance Strategist

The City University of New York

New York, NY

Re: Chief Data and Governance Strategist (University Dean)

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am applying for the Chief Data and Governance Strategist position. I have spent twenty years building enterprise data governance in the environment that punishes weak governance fastest — federally regulated banking — and I am now a doctoral researcher studying how people and AI systems make decisions together. CUNY is at the point where those two things have to be the same job.

Enterprise data governance, at institutional scale. At Citi I centralized **500+ legal-entity data sources** into governed master data, which enabled automated FR2900 and TIC regulatory filings at **99.8% accuracy**. That work was the unglamorous core of data governance: defining ownership, reconciling conflicting sources of truth, establishing stewardship, and making the resulting data trustworthy enough to file with the Federal Reserve. A university system with 25 campuses has the same structural problem — many local systems, one institutional truth, and a reporting obligation that cannot be wrong.

Governance that holds up under external scrutiny. As a former **OCC bank examiner**, I have sat on the regulator's side of the table; at Citi I led consent-order remediation and issue-closure packages reviewed by quality assurance and external regulators. I know how to build a governance program that survives an outside audit rather than one that merely documents intentions — and how to report it credibly to a Board.

AI governance, already built rather than theorized. I authored an AI governance framework for Citi's internal governance team referencing **NIST AI RMF and SR 11-7**, covering model inventory, risk tiering, explainability, and human-in-the-loop controls. I also built the technology: a retrieval-augmented document assistant that cut review cycle time **~35%**. My doctoral research at FIU is an IRB-approved empirical study of automation bias — when professionals stop exercising judgment because a system sounded confident. Universities are deciding right now how AI touches admissions, advising, assessment, and student records. Those decisions need someone who can write the policy, evaluate the model, and understand the human factors — and who will say plainly where the evidence runs out.

An honest framing of the lateral. My governance career is financial services, not higher education. I have not administered FERPA, and I would be learning CUNY's shared-governance culture, faculty senate norms, and enrollment-reporting obligations rather than arriving fluent in them. What transfers is the harder, slower part: building a data governance function from a standing start across a federated organization, earning the trust of local stewards who did not ask for oversight, and holding a standard when the institution is under external examination. The regulatory vocabulary changes; the discipline does not.

What draws me specifically to CUNY is that it is a public institution whose data serves students rather than shareholders — and that a role at this level sits close to the academic mission I am already committed to as a doctoral candidate and prospective faculty member. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss the position with the committee.

Sincerely,

Yasir A. Malik

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